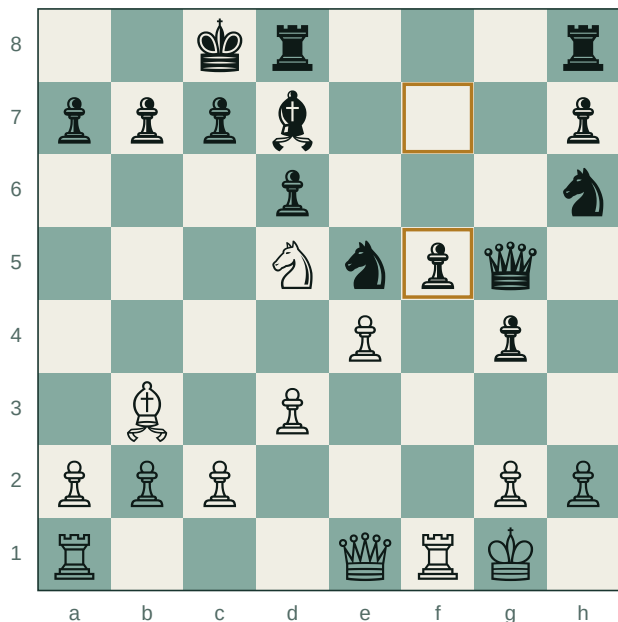


Queenside attacks: White, move 17

Queenside attacks

White to move



Previous move: 16...f5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

17. Qa5 Kb8 18. Qxc7+ Ka8 19. Qxd6

17.Qa5 The queen moves from e1 to a5. Recorded reply: **17...Kb8**.

18.Qxc7+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. From c7 it attacks king on b8, rook on d8 and bishop on d7. Recorded reply: **18...Ka8**.

19.Qxd6 The queen captures the pawn on d6. From d6 it attacks knight on h6, knight on e5 and bishop on d7.

At the end, nominal material is White 32 / Black 33 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +2. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +2: the balance goes from -3 to -1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

The board's left half is not inherently safe. Queen checks and rook entries can make a queenside king as vulnerable as a kingside one.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An attack on the queenside can target a castled king, a vulnerable pawn, or trapped pieces. Files and entry squares matter more than simply advancing flank pawns.

HOW TO LOOK

Locate the critical target and which pawn or piece move opens a route toward it. Check whether central counterplay interrupts the plan.

The defending king is on c8. Geometrically undefended: queen on g5. Check for tactical protection.